

FURNITURE



EVERY DAY, PEOPLE SIT on chairs, sleep in beds, and eat from tables. All these are items of furniture, the movable equipment of a home.

At one time, furniture was handmade, so most homes contained only basic, functional pieces. A wide range of more affordable furniture became available when production was mechanized in the 19th century. Today, furniture design is largely determined by function, cost, size, and fashion.

Types of furniture

Furniture made for use in a home is designed to be as comfortable as possible. Choices of shape and fabric let the buyer express personal taste. Office furniture is usually plainer and more functional. Furniture is found outdoors in the form of litter bins, street lamps, and bus stops.

Domestic furniture

Most homes have a bed or a futon. Originally created in Japan for modern, urban life, the futon saves space by serving as a bed at night and a sofa during the day.



Office furniture

Modern office furniture, such as this Anglepoise lamp, is designed to be practical, sturdy, and long-lasting.



The lamp head is easily adjusted.

The heavy base provides balance.



Street furniture

Despite having similar functions, street furniture looks very different all over the world. This elaborate public drinking fountain is in Paris, France.



The chairs in this Roman sculpture are similar to modern chairs.

Antique furniture

Antiques are objects made more than 100 years ago. Antique furniture was usually handcrafted, using fine materials, in many different styles. Antiques are frequently considered valuable and are highly prized by collectors today.



An 18th-century cabinet

How an armchair is made

Most modern furniture is mass-produced by machine rather than handcrafted. Furniture such as sofas and armchairs have machine-made parts that are fitted together by hand and then upholstered. This armchair is made from materials that have been built up around a wooden frame.

Steel springs attached to the frame help spread a person's weight evenly.

Arms are cushioned with foam padding and a fleece layer.

Upholsterer fits the fabric covering securely into position.

Castors are small wheels beneath the chair that allow it to be moved easily.



Metal springs make the chair comfortable to sit on.

Layers of metal mesh and hessian hold the springs in place.

Cushions are filled with foam or feathers.

Fabric covering is durable.

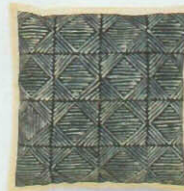
Interior design

In furnishing a room, people try to choose colours, pictures, fabrics, and furniture that go well together. This process is known as interior design. It began in Europe in the 16th century, when furniture makers were first given charge of entire rooms to decorate as a unified whole.



Soft furnishings are materials such as rugs, cushions, and curtains. These materials are chosen to make a room comfortable and to help create its overall look.

Cushions and wall-paper borders are coordinated.



William Morris

The British designer, artist, and socialist William Morris (1834–96) was active in many areas. He was influential in the design of furniture and fabrics, argued for a return to handcrafted furniture, and founded the Arts and Crafts Movement for design.



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